

Primary Source Reading 1: Euthyphro's First Definitions

Optima Academy Online | Philosophy & Ethics | High School Honors (9–12) From Plato's Euthyphro, translated by Benjamin Jowett Read before Lesson 2a: Introduction to Doing Philosophy

Before you read: Socrates has been indicted for impiety and is waiting outside the court of the King Archon when he runs into Euthyphro, who is there on business of his own — he intends to prosecute his own father for murder. Euthyphro is completely confident that this is the pious thing to do. Socrates, characteristically, wants to know what piety actually is before he decides whether to be impressed. As you read, watch how Euthyphro's first two attempts at a definition are each shown to fail, and notice exactly *why* each one fails — the reasons matter as much as the failures themselves.

The Case Against His Father

SOCRATES: And of what is he accused?

EUTHYPHRO: Of murder, Socrates.

SOCRATES: By the powers, Euthyphro! How little does the common herd know of the nature of right and truth. A man must be an extraordinary man, and have made great strides in wisdom, before he could have seen his way to bring such an action.

EUTHYPHRO: Indeed, Socrates, he must.

SOCRATES: I suppose that the man whom your father murdered was one of your relatives?

EUTHYPHRO: ...Now the man who is dead was a poor dependent of mine who worked for us as a field labourer on our farm in Naxos, and one day in a fit of drunken passion he got into a quarrel with one of our domestic servants and slew him. My father bound him hand and foot and threw him into a ditch, and then sent to Athens to ask of a diviner what he should do with him. Meanwhile he never attended to him and took no care about him, for he regarded him as a murderer... For such was the effect of cold and hunger and chains upon him, that before the messenger returned from the diviner, he was dead. And my father and family are angry with me for taking the part of the murderer and prosecuting my father. They say that... a son is impious who prosecutes a father. Which shows, Socrates, how little they know what the gods think about piety and impiety. (*Euthyphro*, 4b–e)

What Is Piety?

SOCRATES: I adjure you to tell me the nature of piety and impiety... Is not piety in every action always the same? and impiety, again — is it not always the opposite of piety, and also the same with itself, having, as impiety, one notion which includes whatever is impious?

EUTHYPHRO: To be sure, Socrates.

SOCRATES: And what is piety, and what is impiety?

EUTHYPHRO: Piety is doing as I am doing; that is to say, prosecuting any one who is guilty of murder, sacrilege, or of any similar crime — whether he be your father or mother, or whoever he may be — that makes no difference; and not to prosecute them is impiety. (5c–d)

SOCRATES: No doubt, Euthyphro; but you would admit that there are many other pious acts?

EUTHYPHRO: There are.

SOCRATES: Remember that I did not ask you to give me two or three examples of piety, but to explain the general idea which makes all pious things to be pious... Tell me what is the nature of this idea, and then I shall have a standard to which I may look, and by which I may measure actions, whether yours or those of any one else, and then I shall be able to say that such and such an action is pious, such another impious. (6d–e)

Piety Is What the Gods Love

EUTHYPHRO: Piety, then, is that which is dear to the gods, and impiety is that which is not dear to them. (6e–7a)

SOCRATES: Very good, Euthyphro; you have now given me the sort of answer which I wanted. Come, then, and let us examine what we are saying. That thing or person which is dear to the gods is pious, and that thing or person which is hateful to the gods is impious, these two being the extreme opposites of one another. Was not that said?

EUTHYPHRO: It was.

SOCRATES: And further, the gods were admitted to have enmities and hatreds and differences?

EUTHYPHRO: Yes, that was also said.

SOCRATES: But what differences are there which make us angry and set us at enmity with one another? I will suggest that these enmities arise when the matters of difference are the just and unjust, good and evil, honourable and dishonourable. Are not these the points about which men differ, and about which, when we are unable satisfactorily to decide our differences, we quarrel?

EUTHYPHRO: Yes, Socrates, the nature of the differences about which we quarrel is such as you describe.

SOCRATES: And the quarrels of the gods, noble Euthyphro, when they occur, are of a like nature? They have differences of opinion about good and evil, just and unjust, honourable and dishonourable — there would have been no quarrels among them, if there had been no such differences, would there?

EUTHYPHRO: You are quite right. (7b–e)

The Contradiction

SOCRATES: Does not every man love that which he deems noble and just and good, and hate the opposite of them?

EUTHYPHRO: Very true.

SOCRATES: But, as you say, people regard the same things, some as just and others as unjust — about these they dispute; and so there arise wars and fightings among them. Then the same things are hated by the gods and loved by the gods, and are both hateful and dear to them?

EUTHYPHRO: True.

SOCRATES: And upon this view the same things, Euthyphro, will be pious and also impious?

EUTHYPHRO: So I should suppose.

SOCRATES: Then, my friend, I remark with surprise that you have not answered the question which I asked. For I certainly did not ask you to tell me what action is both pious and impious: but now it would seem that what is loved by the gods is also hated by them. And therefore, Euthyphro, in thus chastising your father you may very likely be doing what is agreeable to Zeus but disagreeable to Cronos or Uranus, and what is acceptable to Hephaestus but unacceptable to Hera, and there may be other gods who have similar differences of opinion. (7e–8b)